

Lecture 15 – Structuralism and Cultural Signs

Saussure

- Language is not a collection of names for things. It is a structured system of differences. To explain this, Saussure introduces what becomes one of the most influential ideas in twentieth-century theory: the sign. Every sign, he argues, is made up of two inseparable components.
- Signifier. This is the physical form of the sign: the sound you hear when a word is spoken, the marks you see on a page (later applied to images, styles)
- Signified. This is the concept associated with the signifier—not the thing itself, but the mental idea of it.
- Culturalist - lived experience, historical context, and agency.
Structuralist - the deep structures that organise meaning.
- This model can be applied beyond language but also in terms of images, fashion, food, advertising, film, news, and popular culture.

Barthes

- Barthes argues that in modern culture, signs often operate at two levels, not just one (sign / signifier).
- The first level is denotation. This is the most literal, descriptive level of meaning. What we might call “what we see”. At the level of denotation, this appears neutral and factual.
- At the second level, we have connotation. This is where cultural associations, values, and emotions come into play. The man does not simply wear a suit. The suit connotes professionalism, success, authority. The car does not simply exist. It connotes freedom, masculinity, status, aspiration.
- Myth, for Barthes, is a mode of signification. A myth is a way of making historically specific, culturally constructed meanings appear natural, timeless, and obvious.

Semiology and semiotics

- Semiology is the study of signs in society (not just linguistic signs)
- Semiotics (or semiology) is the study of signs, symbols, and signification. It is the study of how meaning is created.
- Elements that can be altered and still retain the same meaning

Critique and the work of Stuart Hall

Structuralism is extremely powerful at explaining how meaning is organised, but it is much less good at explaining power and inequality in concrete social contexts, media institutions and production and audience interpretation and resistance Hall was deeply influenced by Saussure and Barthes. He does not abandon structuralism. Instead, he reworks it, combining semiology with Marxism, ideology theory, and sociology.